

Garden Life: Hedgehogs

A simple, practical guide to making a UK garden friendlier to hedgehogs.

A hedgehog does not necessarily need a bought house.

Quiet dry spaces under sheds, shrubs, log piles and leaf piles can all be useful.

If a hedgehog may already be nesting under a shed, leave the nest undisturbed.

Start with the garden you already have

Keep routes through the garden open.

Leave some dry leaves and dead plant material in a quiet corner.

Keep netting and litter off the ground where animals can become trapped.

Provide shallow fresh water, especially in dry weather.

A simple hedgehog shelter

Choose a shady, quiet, dry place protected from the prevailing wind.

A sturdy reused box can work if it is stable, ventilated and weatherproof.

Purpose-built homes often use an entrance tunnel or internal baffle.

Dry leaves make useful bedding material.

Do not use creosote, solvent-based preservatives or strongly treated timber.

Do not inspect an occupied nest, especially during hibernation or breeding.

RSPB DIY guide:

<https://www.rspb.org.uk/helping-nature/what-you-can-do/activities/build-a-hedgehog-house>

Feeding and water

Supplementary food can help when natural prey is scarce.

Offer meaty cat or dog food, cat biscuits, or suitable meat-based hedgehog food.

Always provide fresh water.

Put feeding bowls away from the sleeping nest.

Clean bowls regularly.

Do not give milk or bread.

A simple feeding station can be made from a sturdy storage box.

An entrance around 13 cm square is commonly used for hedgehog access.

Solitary bees live here too

Mason bees and leaf-cutting bees are solitary bees, not hive bees.

Leaf-cutters carry neat pieces of leaf into nest tunnels.

Mason bees use mud or similar material to divide nest cells.

A simple bee hotel can use untreated solid wood or hollow bamboo.

Use smooth blind-ended holes in several sizes, roughly 2-10 mm across.

About 8 mm is suitable for red mason bees.

Fix the hotel firmly in a sunny sheltered place and keep it dry.

RSPB DIY bee-hotel guide:

<https://www.rspb.org.uk/helping-nature/what-you-can-do/activities/build-a-bee-hotel>

More Garden Life resources

For checked DIY guidance, ready-made hedgehog and bee-house links, and the wider Aletheia Waste to Garden collection, visit:

<https://swindon.org.uk/resources/aletheia-waste-to-garden-rsc.htm>

The resource page is deliberately shared rather than creating a separate commercial page for every animal or PDF.

Free knowledge first. Shopping links are optional.